

New Years 2010: A snowshoe, a scout, and a bivy to start the new year out right

After surviving the holidays it's once again time to ramp up the wilderness trips! January sees the start of the Sierra Club Wilderness Travel Course where I'm a volunteer instructor and at the same time I'll be taking a multi pitch rock climbing class through the Southern California Mountaineers Association. The combination will keep me reasonably busy through April so I had to fit in as much other stuff as possible the first few weeks of January.

One of those things I wanted to squeeze in was the provisional trip for my next level of Sierra Club rating. This time it's for the M-Rock level which means leading groups up 3rd class (hand and feet required in order to proceed) terrain. Think this:



After much last minute planning and negotiation with various parties I had a plan for leading the trip to Death Valley January 16th & 17th. The only catch is I needed to scout the peak ahead of time. This turned into a bit of an adventure (imagine that!)

But before all this there was the Christmas trip out to Colorado where I was able to get enough time off to spend over a week at my grandfathers. After a few days of depressingly sunny weather a storm came through and dropped a nice amount of fresh snow.

We went from this:



To this:



I charged out with my customary enthusiasm each day to hike or snowshoe despite (or possibly because of) the weather.



Kim arrived a few days later and followed along with her own customary enthusiasm:



The highlight was actually on Christmas Day when 3 degree weather and fresh snowfall combined to make an excellent snowshoe up towards Cameron Pass. Kim had slightly less fun as by the end of the trip she has ice formed on her eyebrows and eye lashes and all her exposed hair was white with frost.





Soon though it was time to return to reality and I flew back to Boise to work for another week before flying back to California the evening of the 31st.

Day 1: Starting off the new year right

Bright and early January 1st 2010 I prodded a mostly asleep Kim into my truck and took off towards San Jacinto to take part in the annual New Year's Day snowshoe put on by two Sierra Club Leaders.

Sadly the weather was extremely mild and we had to settle for a sunny day with awesome visibility from the summit.



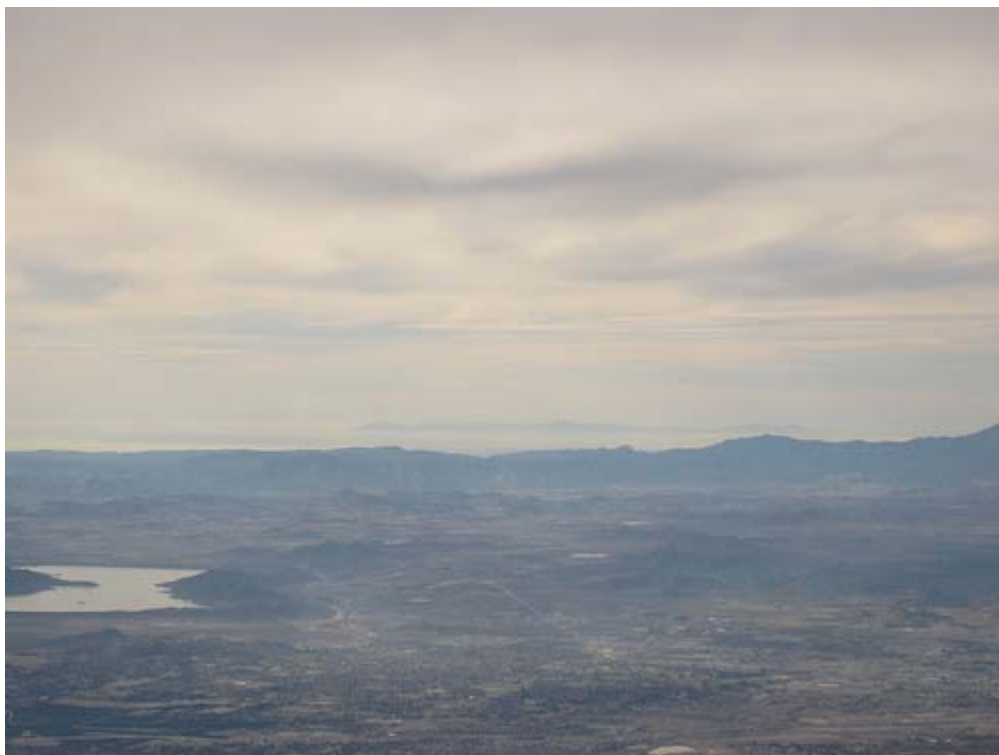


Up on the peak we had a relaxing rest and posed for pictures.





We could actually make out Catalina from the top



And of course, San Geronio



And as always with snow trips the descent is much faster than the climb. We were able to glissade large amounts of the downhill slope.



We returned to the tramway just as it was getting dark and enjoyed a beautiful sunset as we waited in line for the tram down.



After a quick dinner in Palm Springs Kim and set off for the 4 or 5 hour drive out to Shoshone just to the south of Death Valley. We arrived a little after 11:30 pm and after following a short sequence of dirt roads we came to a parking area beside the dry Amarigosa riverbed.



Rather than set up a tent I gave Kim and cab of my truck and I took the bed and we laid out sleeping bags and went to sleep. Despite my zero degree sleeping bag I had dressed rather lightly and by morning I woke up shivering. Fortunately it warmed up a bit once the sun rose.

Day 2: Bivy-what now?



In the early morning light Kim and I went about getting ready and set off for the main goal, Eagle Mountain (#2 according to Sierra Club Desert Peak Section as there is more than one mountain named Eagle)



The standard route up Eagle #2 involves walking a bearing to the base of three chutes then climbing up the left hand chute to a band of white rock where you transition to the middle chute and continue to the ridge. Once on the ridge you follow it south to the summit which is reputed to have a bit of exposure at times.

Though this route did contain some class 3 terrain it was not enough to qualify for my provisional outing. Also it was boring. So after talking with the Sierra Club rock chair I was out to find a new more difficult route.

(I would like to add that I do believe this is the first time in recent memory I've been accused of trying to do a trip the easy way.)



Kim and I set off to the south across the desert floor as I eyed potential routes.



I dismissed a few interesting looking route that looked like they might turn into 5th class sections and after about a mile and a quarter I found a promising looking ridge and led a rather pretty climb.



Kim is having fun; you can tell by the way she's glaring at me...





Kim was getting a bit tired and after eyeing the time I dropped her off at a small bench and set off alone to scout the last section to the summit. This part was a lot of fun though I ended up in a few precarious spots as I looked for the best route to the summit itself.

After climbing the bumps to either side of the peak I made my way to the peak itself and found a rather lightly visited register waiting for me.

I dropped back down from the summit ridge yelling over to Kim that I was on my way back. Soon I was back to the spot where I had left her with a little over two hours to go before dark I thought we had plenty of time to descend.

We traversed over to the use trail marking the standard route well below the ridge which saved us from any exposure or rock scrambling. We did have to deal with loose terrain and Kim was having a rough time with her balance which slowed us down greatly.

By the time we reached the chute we would use to descend over an hour had passed and the sun had almost reached the far ridge and I was getting concerned.



It was basically a 1500 ft straight shot down the chute with only minor 3rd class moves in two areas. Unfortunately it was a bit steep and the loose rocks continued to be a challenge for Kim.

As the last of the sun dropped below the far ridge it was increasingly obvious we weren't going to make it down before dark.



We both had headlamps which we donned as it grew dark but the loose terrain combined with the darkness was making Kim extremely nervous and it soon became apparent to me that it wasn't safe to continue.



So, there we were. Having Kim descend any further in the dark wasn't safe. Leaving Kim up there and heading down to the car by myself was an option wouldn't have been very nice so I found us a small flat patch of ground and started going through our supplies.

The good news was I had carried extra water and food so we were fine there. We also has the usual emergency fire starting material in case it grew too cold but due to the large rope I was carrying as a requirement of the trip I had along much less cold weather gear than usual. We also only had a single emergency blanket between the two of us.



It was a little after 6 pm and the sun wouldn't come up for roughly 12 hours. We put on our extra gear and settled down as comfortably as we could considering we were laying on a small rocky platform.

At first it actually rather comfortable as the temperature was still in the 60s and there wasn't much wind. But as the hours wore on it grew increasingly colder and on top of that sometime after midnight the wind started up. By two in the morning both Kim and I were folded into small balls trying to remain under the emergency blanket as well as we could.

Emergency blankets are generally made of very light weight foil and as a result the wind will snatch them out of your hands unless you keep a tight grip. Since there were two of us under a blanket made for one there was not enough material to tuck it underneath us and the wind kept blowing underneath making it quite chilly. I tried to remedy this by putting rocks around the outside of the blanket to hold it against the ground but they had a habit of coming off every time one of us moved.

In addition the rocks we were laying on dug into us no matter what we did and I couldn't keep the same position for more than 30 or 40 minutes without needing to shift. When one of us needed to shift the other out of necessity had to as well which in turn sent all the rocks rolling off the edge of the blanket.

This went on for the next 12 hours.

Sometime around midnight I looked out from under the blanket and saw what looked like cloud cover had come over the far ridge and was marching across the valley towards us. Over the next hours I watched it getting closer and was quietly concerned. We were fine but if the weather changed things could get uncomfortable. Finally the clouds were right below us.

It was the moon. There was a blue moon that night and it was bright enough it lit up the ground and made things look white in the distance.

After a near eternity under that dusty blanket the sky finally started to brighten.





We loaded everything back in our packs and I tried to get us moving as soon as possible to get warm.

Again our progress was slow but by 9:15 am we were at long last back to my truck.



An entire day for a 4 or 5 mile round trip, that's got to be a record for me.

I had plans to scout some other peaks in the area but after getting back to the car I made the call to take Kim out to eat and head home instead since the other peaks all involved much longer mileage.



Kim doing her survival dance at the world famous Crowbar in the thriving metropolis of Shoshone. (ie the only restaurant in a town that spans all of a few blocks)

So that was it for the scout. I had enough information on Eagle and felt confident enough in the published routes for the other two peaks that I felt I was ready for my provisional a few weeks later...